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Former head of the Tax and Customs Administration: benefits scandal is a man-made disaster

The childcare allowance affair is a man-made disaster. "This is a derailed train," said Jaap Uijlenbroek, former Director-General of the Tax and Customs Administration, during his questioning by the parliamentary inquiry committee. He concludes that all the circuits and fuses failed and that it was discovered far too late that there was a fundamental flaw in the system.

Mistakes were made "from the highest level to the very lowest," according to Uijlenbroek, who led the Tax and Customs Administration from early 2017 to early 2020. "That is how trains derail." According to him, no individual culprits can be identified, but the entire government apparatus is responsible: "The House of Representatives, the government, and the functioning of the civil service."

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Former head of the Tax and Customs Administration: derailed train

Upon taking office in 2017, Uijlenbroek received a handover file in which allowances were not mentioned at all. "The problems lay in other areas," he said. And those were problems caused "by long-term neglect." "That has not yet been resolved and will not be resolved in the coming years either." He speaks of excessive efficiency thinking at the Tax and Customs Administration.

The problems with childcare allowances were viewed for too long as an individual problem of parents at a specific childminder agency that had made administrative errors. It was not until June 2019, when RTL and Trouw reported on it, that the full extent of this "disaster in slow motion" became clear to him. Until then, "no one had told me that there was a very big problem here that had been going on for years. It only really dawned on me very late."

The reporting by RTL and Trouw caused a shift in thinking. Only then did Uijlenbroek, as the top boss, also acknowledge that thousands of people were the victims. "But even then, we did not yet make the observation: we could have fixed this two years ago."

At the beginning of his questioning, Uijlenbroek reflected on the pain of the parents. He pointed out that the government is supposed to protect citizens and that things "went completely wrong" at the Tax and Customs Administration. He noted that the effects on many people are enormous and that the case has led to divorces and evictions. He emphasized that, to this day, there are parents waiting for compensation.

After Uylenbroek, Manon Leijten was questioned. She served as Secretary-General at the Ministry of Finance between 2013 and 2019, advising the Minister and State Secretary. In that capacity, she attended many meetings and reviewed important documents. The childcare allowance dossier affects her deeply, she said. "Given this responsibility, I feel terrible about what happened to these people." However, she was unable to answer many questions from the inquiry commission. "I do not have as good a memory as others who have sat here."

This became apparent when committee member Leijten (SP) wanted to know why the 2017 memo regarding a compensation scheme for parents had suddenly disappeared:

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Where has the advice to compensate parents gone?

Read previous articles about the Childcare Allowance Inquiry Committee here:

Senior SZW official: Tax and Customs Administration conducted ['fraud hunt'](#) against parents

[Former tax chief](#) : tough approach to 'benefit parents' wish of Social Affairs

Director of Benefits: [pressure](#) on the Tax and Customs Administration was high and the policy was not ours

There was [no room](#) for a less strict approach to parents receiving benefits.

Lawyer: benefits scandal reminiscent of Kafka, ran into a [wall](#)

Former Tax and Customs Administration director: [stomach ache](#) over benefits scandal, top brass knew about it